infallible; we had them at 132–6 in the first innings, before Johnson and Brad Haddin put on 114. Would Johnson, who took nine wickets in the match, be able to keep blowing us away? Would Harris revert to type and struggle to sustain himself physically over a series?

As it turned out, the answers were yes, and no.

Something clicked for Johnson only two overs into the series, when he opted to bowl around the wicket, to a spread field. A sensational bowler who went through massive peaks and troughs, he suddenly found he could take wickets with his bad balls. Confidence surged; by the end, he was in complete control. Harris would be forced to retire in 2015 through a knee injury, but these were the days of his life.

The part of my brain that deals in logic, analytical thought and reasoning was occupied by the fragile, overarching goals of the tour. The other part, more creative, and focused on such things as imagination, intuition, insight and holistic thought, was devoted to Trotty's plight. In short, could I have done any more to help?

It is something I wrestle with to this day. My mind keeps returning to a session with the bowling machine during the warm-up period in Sydney. It is one of my major regrets that I never stopped it. Trotty seemed to be intent on purging himself. He turned the machine up to top speed and was being hit all over the body. It was alarming, unprecedented in my experience for its wilful destructiveness.

I didn't have the confidence or ability to do my job as a leader. I knew he was struggling mentally, and confiding in Mark Saxby, the masseur with whom he had a strong relationship, but I failed to appreciate the extent of the problem. In the later years of my captaincy I would have been more forceful and proactive, and demanded to be allowed into the inner circle.

Trotty has subsequently admitted to me that he regrets not sharing his issues, because he didn't want to burden me. That's where self-containment, encouraged and almost demanded by international sport, works against the individual. He later wrote of having his male dignity stripped away by his perceived inability to deal with the short ball.

There is a tightrope strung between leaving someone alone and trusting them to do things their way, and wrapping them in cotton wool. This, remember, was a senior player who had been part of three Ashes-winning teams. He had scored one helluva lot of runs over forty-seven Tests.